

What should I believe?

If you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-questions.

When should I form a
new belief?

When should I discard
one of my beliefs?

Positive rules of belief will tell you
when you should form a certain
belief.

If you are in such-and-such
circumstances, you should
believe P.

Negative rules of belief will tell you
when you should not have a certain
belief.

If you are in such-and-such
circumstances, you should not
believe P.

It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive and negative rules of belief.

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form the belief.)

We'll be trying, for the next three classes, to improve upon these two rules by trying to formulate rules of belief which we could actually put to use.

Why would we want to do this? We all face cases where it is not clear what we should believe. It is genuinely hard to know what to do in this kind of situation. And it is hard to see how to figure it out other than by trying to figure out what the rules of belief are.

Falsity $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If P is false, you should
not believe P.

Truth $\rightarrow$ Belief

If P is true, you
should believe P.

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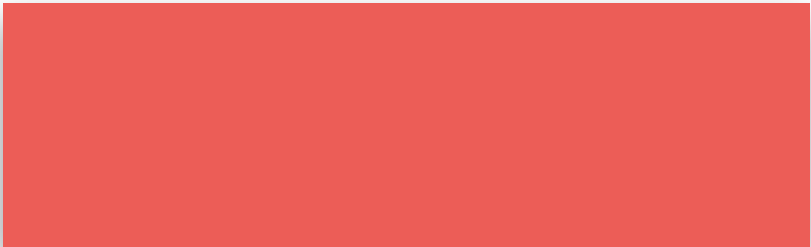
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infinite IR.

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If P is true, you



Shrividevi IR.





